

COMPARATIVE FINANCIAL ANALYTICS AND STRATEGIC EXPANSION

Johnson & Johnson vs. The Procter & Gamble Company
2019–2021

A Financial Analysis Portfolio

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MBA Project Reconstruction and Independent Analytical Extension

Portfolio provenance: This report reconstructs and extends an MBA Financial Accounting project. This project validates key figures against company Form 10-K filings to draw business and financial insights using data.

Abstract

This study compares Johnson & Johnson (J&J) and The Procter & Gamble Company (P&G) over fiscal years 2019–2021 using a structured financial-statement-analysis framework.

The analysis integrates profitability and earnings quality, liquidity, operating efficiency, solvency and leverage, product/segment growth, geographic expansion, and acquisition/divestiture activity. The underlying evidence combines the original MBA project tables, geographic-expansion workbook, and primary-source Form 10-K disclosures. The analysis uses cross-sectional comparison, time-series analysis, ratio analysis, growth decomposition, segment and geographic disaggregation, and visual analytics.

Results show a differentiated financial profile: J&J exhibited higher gross margins, stronger liquidity, lower balance-sheet leverage, and substantially higher interest coverage, while P&G displayed superior working-capital efficiency, including a negative cash conversion cycle. Growth decomposition further shows that J&J's 2019–2021 expansion was disproportionately driven by Pharmaceuticals and international markets, whereas P&G's growth was led by Fabric & Home Care, Health Care, and faster U.S. than international expansion.

The study illustrates how accounting data can be transformed into decision-oriented business insights while also highlighting comparability limits created by different business models, fiscal calendars, and unusual items.

Executive Summary

Core conclusion. *The comparison does not produce a single universal “winner.” J&J’s financial profile emphasizes margin strength, liquidity, debt-service capacity, and pharmaceutical-led international growth; P&G’s profile emphasizes working-capital velocity, consumer-staples resilience, and broad category execution. These differences are economically meaningful because the firms operate distinct portfolios and business models.*

- **Profitability:** J&J maintained materially higher gross margins throughout the period. P&G’s reported 2019 operating and net margins were depressed by a large non-cash goodwill and intangible-asset impairment, making 2020–2021 more representative of normalized performance.
- **Liquidity:** J&J’s current and quick ratios were consistently above P&G’s. P&G nevertheless converted working capital into cash more efficiently, with a negative cash conversion cycle in all three years.
- **Solvency:** J&J carried lower debt-to-assets and debt-to-equity ratios and, contrary to an interpretation in the original class report, had much higher—not lower—interest coverage. Higher coverage indicates stronger capacity to service interest obligations.
- **Product/segment growth:** J&J Pharmaceuticals increased from \$42.2B to \$52.1B; P&G Fabric & Home Care increased from \$22.1B to \$26.0B. These were the largest absolute growth engines in their respective portfolios.
- **Geography:** J&J international sales grew 16.7% from 2019 to 2021 versus 12.0% in the U.S.; P&G U.S. sales grew about 17.8% versus 8.4% internationally.
- **Strategic transactions:** J&J used acquisitions to add healthcare technology and pharmaceutical capabilities while also pruning assets; P&G’s period was characterized more by portfolio simplification and smaller transaction activity after earlier major reshaping.

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1. Research Context and Analytical Objective

Financial statement analysis is most useful when it links reported accounting outcomes to economic questions rather than treating ratios as an end in themselves. The CFA Institute's financial-analysis framework emphasizes defining the analytical purpose, collecting and processing data, comparing performance over time and across firms, interpreting the drivers behind the numbers, and communicating conclusions. This report follows that logic and uses two large, diversified public companies as a comparative case.

The central research question is: **How do differences in profitability, liquidity, operating efficiency, financial risk, product mix, geographic growth, and portfolio transactions reveal the contrasting financial and strategic profiles of J&J and P&G during 2019–2021?**

The project is designed as a business-analytics portfolio rather than an investment recommendation. Its purpose is to demonstrate the transformation of heterogeneous financial disclosures into structured metrics, comparative evidence, visualizations, and managerial interpretation.

1.1 Company Context

J&J was organized during the study period around Consumer Health, Pharmaceutical, and Medical Devices businesses. P&G was organized around five reportable segments: Beauty; Grooming; Health Care; Fabric & Home Care; and Baby, Feminine & Family Care. The firms therefore provide a useful comparison of two global enterprises with different economic engines: healthcare innovation and regulated products on one side, and branded consumer staples on the other.

1.2 Analytical Scope

Dimension	Primary metrics / evidence	Decision question
Profitability & earnings quality	Gross, operating and net margins; ROE; EPS; net earnings	How strong and repeatable are reported earnings?
Liquidity	Current, quick and cash ratios	How comfortably can short-term obligations be met?
Efficiency	Receivables, inventory, payables, operating cycle, cash conversion cycle	How efficiently is working capital converted into cash?
Solvency	Debt/assets, debt/equity, interest coverage	How much financial risk is embedded in the capital structure?
Product / segment	Segment and franchise sales, growth	Which businesses drive growth and diversification?
Geographic expansion	U.S., international and regional sales	Where is growth occurring?
Portfolio strategy	Acquisitions and divestitures	How is management reshaping the asset and capability base?

Source: Analytical design adapted from standard financial-statement-analysis practice (CFA Institute, 2026) and the original MBA project.

2. Data, Reconstruction, and Methodology

2.1 Data Sources

Primary company evidence is drawn from J&J and P&G annual reports on Form 10-K for the relevant fiscal periods. The original MBA report supplies the historical ratio tables and the structure of the analysis. The retained J&J Geographic Expansion workbook supplies geographic and segment-geographic observations, including J&J subsidiary counts.

2.2 Fiscal-Year Comparability

Comparability constraint: J&J and P&G do not share the same fiscal year-end. J&J's fiscal 2019–2021 years ended near calendar year-end (Dec. 29, 2019; Jan. 3, 2021; Jan. 2, 2022), whereas P&G's fiscal years ended June 30. “2019,” “2020,” and “2021” in this report therefore refer to each company's own fiscal-year labels, not identical twelve-month windows.

2.3 Methods

The analysis combines time-series and cross-sectional techniques. Ratios are interpreted jointly rather than in isolation. Growth is measured as percentage change over the study horizon and, where useful, compound annual growth rate (CAGR). Segment and geographic analysis disaggregates consolidated sales to identify contribution patterns. Visual analytics are used to make direction, magnitude, and divergence easier to evaluate.

For a variable X , the two-year growth rate from fiscal 2019 to fiscal 2021 is calculated as $(X_{2021} / X_{2019}) - 1$. CAGR is calculated as $(X_{2021} / X_{2019})^{(1/2)} - 1$. The original MBA project labeled the first measure “average growth rate”; this report relabels it as cumulative 2019–2021 growth to avoid implying an annualized rate.

2.4 Data Quality

The portfolio's data are all drawn from public official sources, including annual reports on Form 10-K.

3. Profitability and Earnings Quality

Profitability analysis asks not only whether earnings are positive, but how effectively revenue is converted into gross profit, operating profit, and bottom-line income. Across 2019–2021, J&J's gross margin remained substantially above P&G's, consistent with the economics of a portfolio containing high-margin pharmaceutical products. Operating margins converged in 2020–2021, while J&J retained a modest advantage in the original ratio table.

Metric	Company	2019	2020	2021
Gross margin	J&J	66.42%	65.58%	68.66%
Gross margin	P&G	48.63%	50.32%	51.25%
Operating margin	J&J	21.12%	19.98%	24.29%
Operating margin	P&G	8.97%	22.32%	23.14%
Net margin	J&J	18.42%	17.82%	22.26%
Net margin	P&G	5.76%	18.36%	18.79%

Source: Original MGT 211 profitability tables; P&G 2019 unusual-item context cross-checked against P&G Form 10-K.

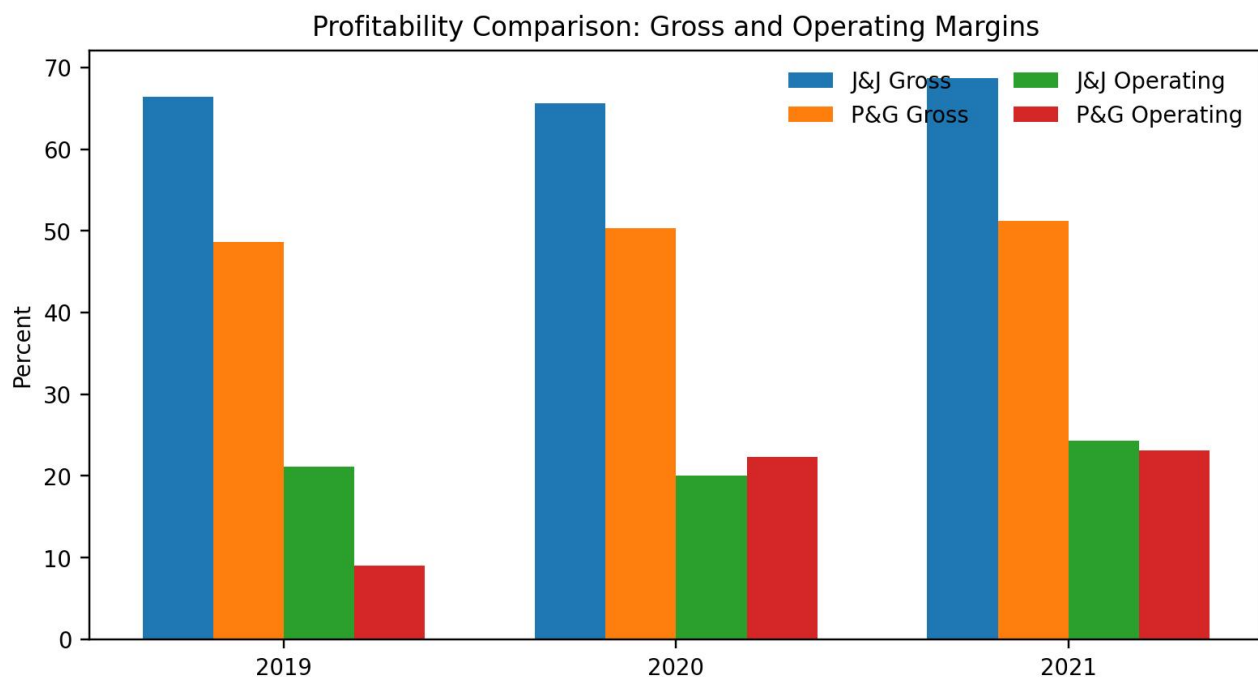


Figure 1. Gross and operating margin comparison

Source: Original MBA ratio tables.

P&G's 2019 operating and net margins require special caution. Its fiscal 2019 Corporate segment included an \$8.3 billion non-cash pre-tax goodwill and intangible-asset impairment charge (\$8.0 billion after tax), which sharply reduced reported operating and net earnings. This is a textbook example of why earnings quality cannot be assessed from a single reported margin without reading the notes and identifying unusual items.

J&J's net earnings in the original project were \$15.1B, \$14.7B, and \$20.9B for 2019–2021. P&G's were approximately \$3.9B, \$13.0B, and \$14.3B. The large P&G rebound is therefore partly a normalization from the 2019 impairment rather than purely an operating-growth story. By 2021, both companies exhibited strong operating profitability, but J&J's gross economics and net margin remained stronger.

3.1 Interpretation for Business Analytics

The analytical lesson is that ratios need context. A model that ranks firms mechanically by a single-year margin would overstate the persistence of P&G's 2019 weakness. A better workflow flags outliers, reconciles them to filing disclosures, and separates recurring operating performance from material non-cash or non-recurring effects.

4. Liquidity and Short-Term Financial Flexibility

J&J maintained higher current and quick ratios in each year, indicating a larger buffer of current and near-liquid assets relative to current liabilities. P&G's current ratio remained below 1.0 throughout the period. That does not automatically imply distress: a large consumer-staples company can operate with structurally low working capital because of predictable cash generation, rapid inventory movement, strong supplier terms, and recurring retail demand.

Ratio	Company	2019	2020	2021
Current	J&J	1.259	1.206	1.348
Current	P&G	0.749	0.627	0.655
Quick	J&J	1.009	0.959	1.112
Quick	P&G	0.582	0.461	0.474
Cash	J&J	0.536	0.530	0.670
Cash	P&G	0.343	0.497	0.311

Source: Original MBA liquidity tables.

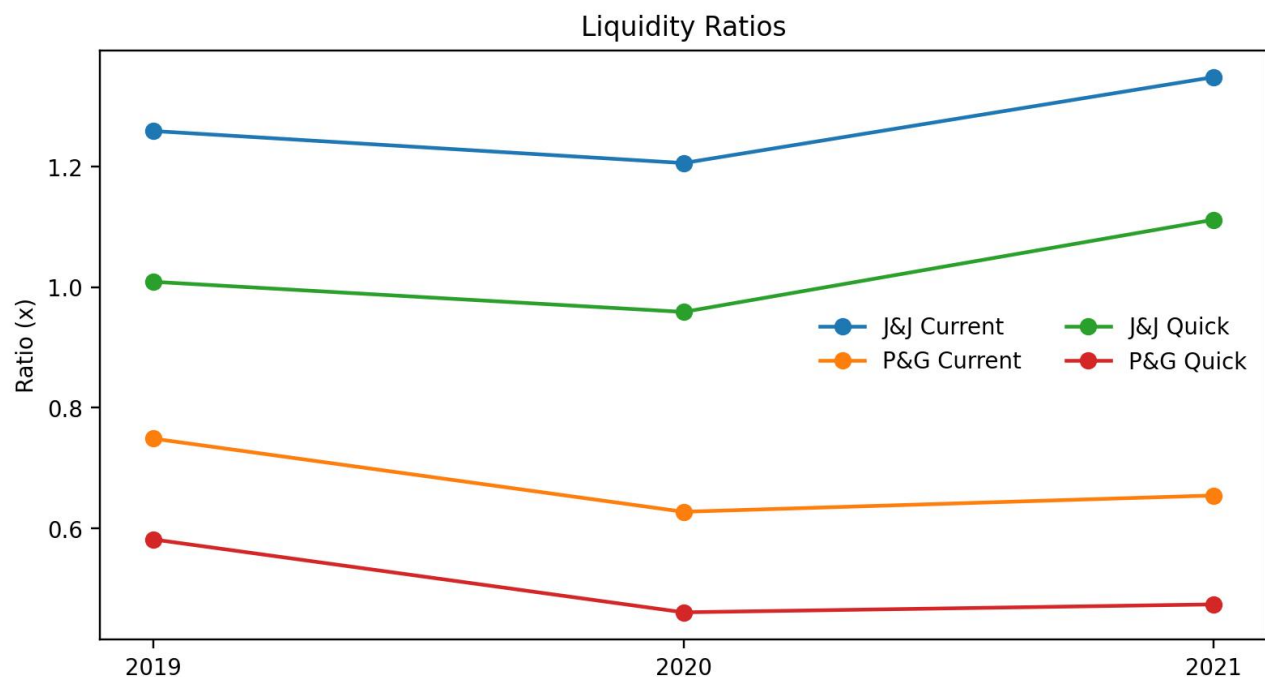


Figure 2. Current and quick ratios

Source: Original MBA ratio tables.

J&J's 2021 current ratio of roughly 1.35 and quick ratio of 1.11 suggest stronger conventional liquidity than P&G's 0.65 and 0.47. However, liquidity should be read together with operating-cycle evidence. P&G's working-capital model makes its low static liquidity ratios less alarming than they would be for a slower-turning or less predictable business.

5. Activity, Turnover, and Working-Capital Efficiency

Efficiency metrics provide one of the clearest contrasts between the firms. P&G's inventory holding period was roughly 51–56 days, versus approximately 117–121 days for J&J. P&G also collected receivables much faster: approximately 21–26 days compared with roughly 56–64 days for J&J. These differences reflect both operating execution and business-model structure.

Metric (days unless noted)	Company	2019	2020	2021
Average collection period	P&G	25.99	23.48	21.35
Average collection period	J&J	63.56	62.00	56.17
Inventory holding period	P&G	51.21	50.44	56.47
Inventory holding period	J&J	116.69	117.99	120.61
Operating cycle	P&G	77.20	77.93	77.82
Operating cycle	J&J	180.25	179.99	176.78
Cash conversion cycle	P&G	-35.58	-41.58	-48.06
Cash conversion cycle	J&J	74.24	65.52	53.90

Source: Original MBA activity/turnover/efficiency tables.

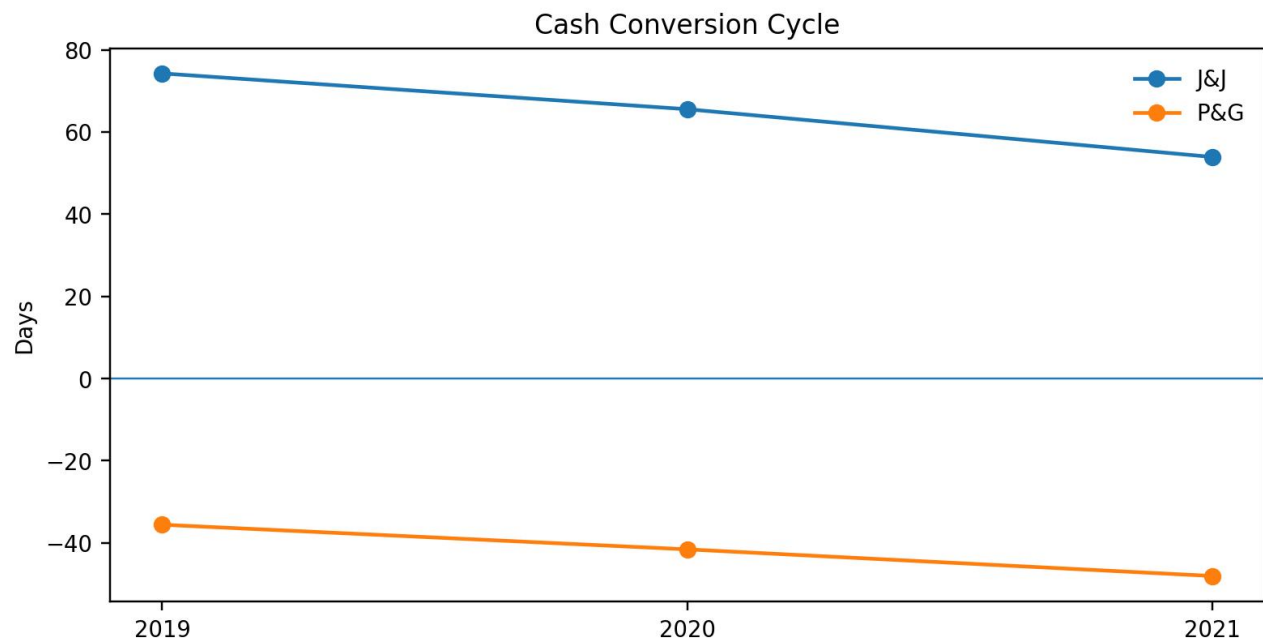


Figure 3. Cash conversion cycle

Source: Original MBA activity/turnover/efficiency tables.

P&G's negative cash conversion cycle is strategically important. It indicates that, on average, cash is collected from customers before the company pays suppliers, allowing operations to be partly financed by trade credit. P&G's 2021 Form 10-K also describes a supply-chain-finance program and extended payment terms; approximately \$5 billion due to participating suppliers was included in accounts payable at June 30, 2021. This disclosure reinforces why payables behavior should be examined alongside headline liquidity ratios.

J&J's cash conversion cycle improved materially—from about 74 days in 2019 to 54 days in 2021—even though it remained positive. That trend indicates meaningful working-capital improvement. The cross-company gap should not be read purely as managerial superiority because pharmaceuticals and medical devices have different production, regulatory, distribution, and receivables characteristics from branded consumer staples.

6. Solvency, Leverage, and Debt-Service Capacity

J&J maintained lower leverage than P&G on both debt-to-assets and debt-to-equity measures across the study period. The difference is economically meaningful but moderate; both firms remained well-established issuers with substantial operating cash-generation capacity.

Metric	Company	2019	2020	2021
Debt / assets	J&J	17.56%	20.16%	18.54%
Debt / assets	P&G	26.15%	28.79%	29.81%
Debt / equity	J&J	0.466	0.557	0.456
Debt / equity	P&G	0.632	0.741	0.687
Interest coverage	J&J	54.50x	82.07x	124.46x
Interest coverage	P&G	11.92x	34.05x	35.10x

Source: Original MBA solvency/leverage tables.

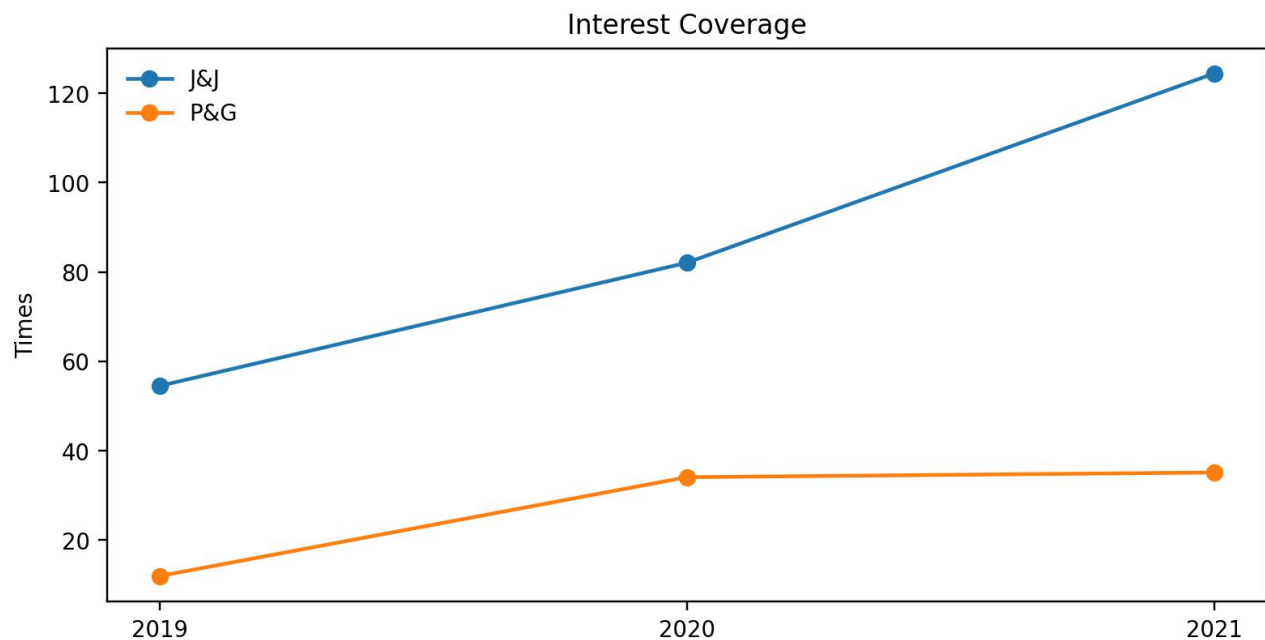


Figure 4. Interest coverage

Source: Original MBA solvency/leverage tables.

The interest-coverage series is especially informative. J&J's coverage increased from roughly 54.5x to 124.5x, while P&G's increased from 11.9x to 35.1x. The conclusion is therefore that J&J demonstrated stronger debt-service coverage.

Taken together with the liquidity results, the solvency evidence portrays J&J as the more conservatively positioned firm on conventional balance-sheet measures during this period. P&G's lower static liquidity and higher leverage are partly offset by exceptionally efficient working-capital conversion and strong recurring consumer demand.

7. Product and Segment Growth Analytics

Segment analysis moves beyond consolidated ratios to identify the economic engines underneath the totals. J&J's portfolio was dominated by Pharmaceuticals, while P&G's largest segment was Fabric & Home Care. The period also captures the uneven COVID-19 shock: J&J Medical Devices fell sharply in 2020 before recovering in 2021, whereas several P&G household and health categories benefited from resilient or elevated at-home consumption.

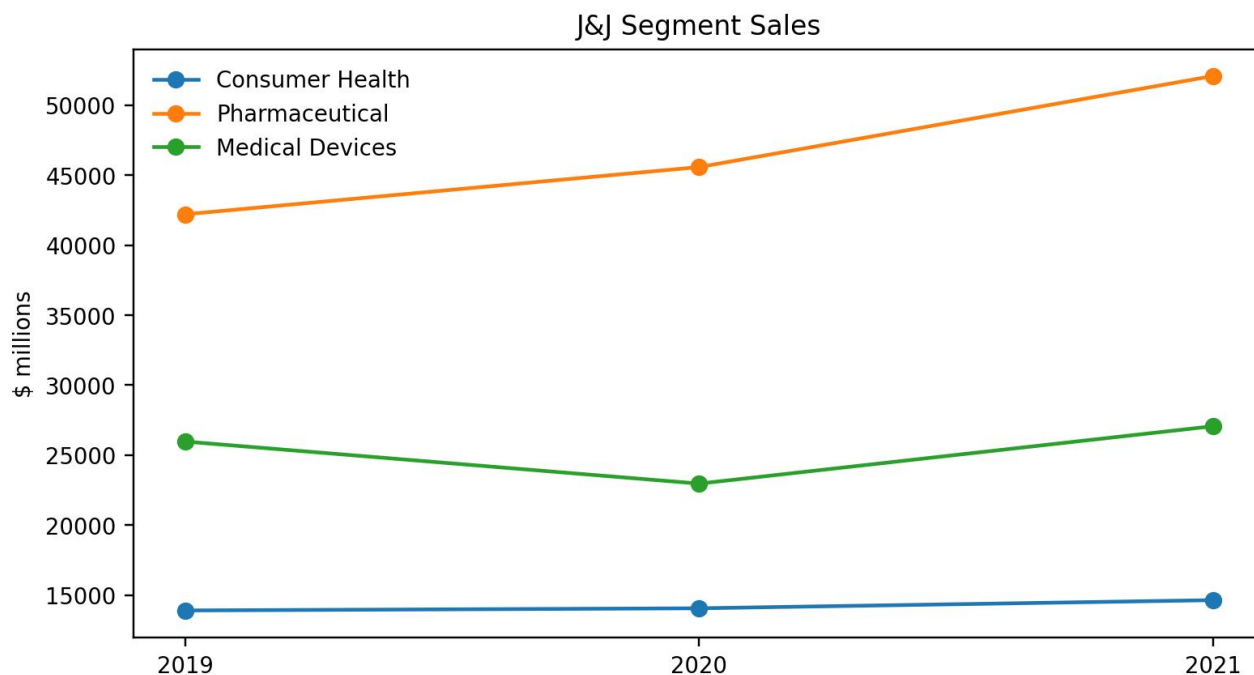


Figure 5. J&J segment sales, 2019–2021

Source: J&J Form 10-K segment disclosures; values in \$ millions.

J&J segment	2019	2020	2021	2019–2021 growth	Approx. CAGR
Consumer Health	13,898	14,053	14,635	5.30%	2.62%
Pharmaceutical	42,198	45,572	52,080	23.42%	11.09%
Medical Devices	25,963	22,959	27,060	4.23%	2.09%

Source: J&J annual reports and retained geographic-expansion workbook.

Pharmaceuticals generated the strongest J&J growth, increasing by nearly \$9.9 billion from 2019 to 2021. Medical Devices fell in 2020 as procedure volumes were disrupted, then rebounded above the 2019 level in 2021. Consumer Health was comparatively stable.

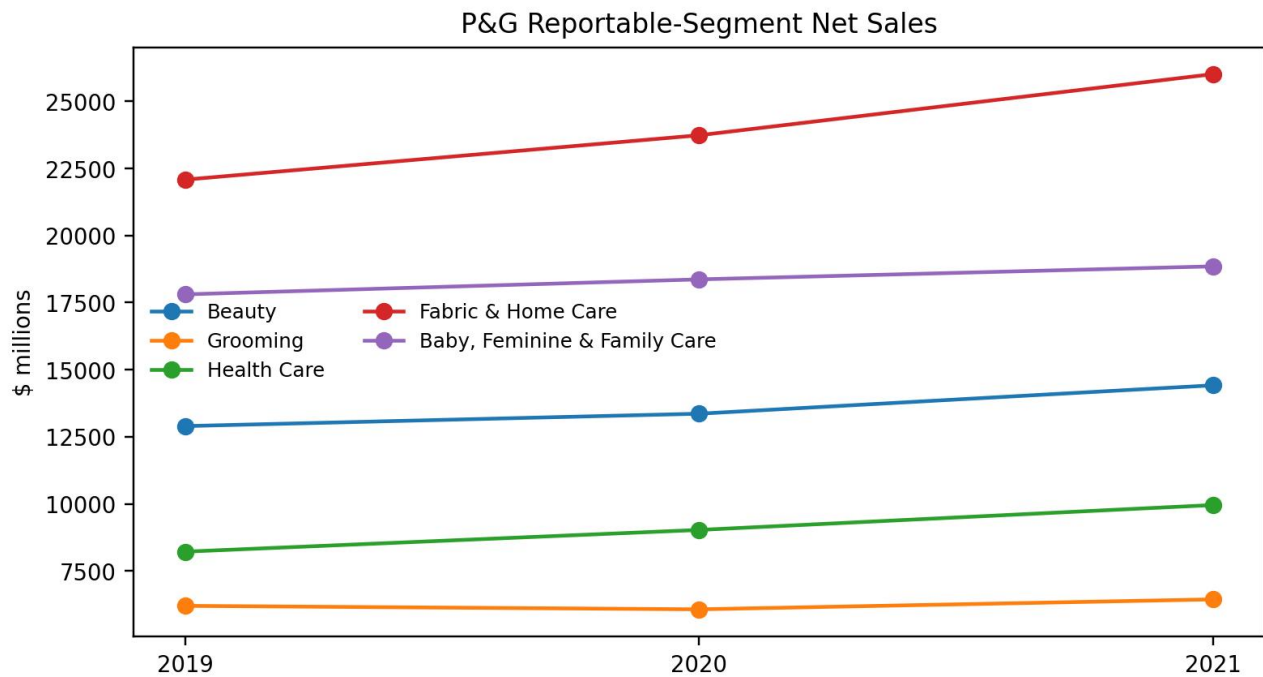


Figure 6. P&G reportable-segment net sales, 2019–2021

Source: P&G FY2021 Form 10-K, Note 2; values in \$ millions.

P&G segment	2019	2020	2021	2019–2021 growth
Beauty	12,897	13,359	14,417	11.79%
Grooming	6,199	6,069	6,440	3.89%
Health Care	8,218	9,028	9,956	21.15%
Fabric & Home Care	22,080	23,735	26,014	17.82%
Baby, Feminine & Family Care	17,806	18,364	18,850	5.86%

Source: P&G FY2021 Form 10-K, Global Segment Results.

P&G's largest absolute segment increase came from Fabric & Home Care, while Health Care posted the fastest percentage growth among the five reportable segments. This pattern supports a more nuanced conclusion than the original assignment's broad statement that P&G focuses on daily necessities: the company's growth during this period was concentrated in household care and health-related categories, while Grooming was comparatively flat.

7.1 Portfolio Structure and Risk

The segment evidence also illustrates diversification trade-offs. J&J's Pharmaceutical segment generated strong growth and high margins but carries patent, regulatory, clinical-development, and pricing risks. P&G's consumer portfolio is less exposed to clinical and patent-expiry risk, but is more sensitive to brand competition, commodity inputs, retail bargaining power, and category-level consumer behavior. Financial analytics becomes more informative when segment growth is interpreted through these underlying economic mechanisms.

8. Geographic Expansion and Internationalization

J&J worldwide sales increased from \$82.1 billion in 2019 to \$93.8 billion in 2021. International sales grew faster than U.S. sales over the two-year horizon, while P&G displayed the opposite pattern.

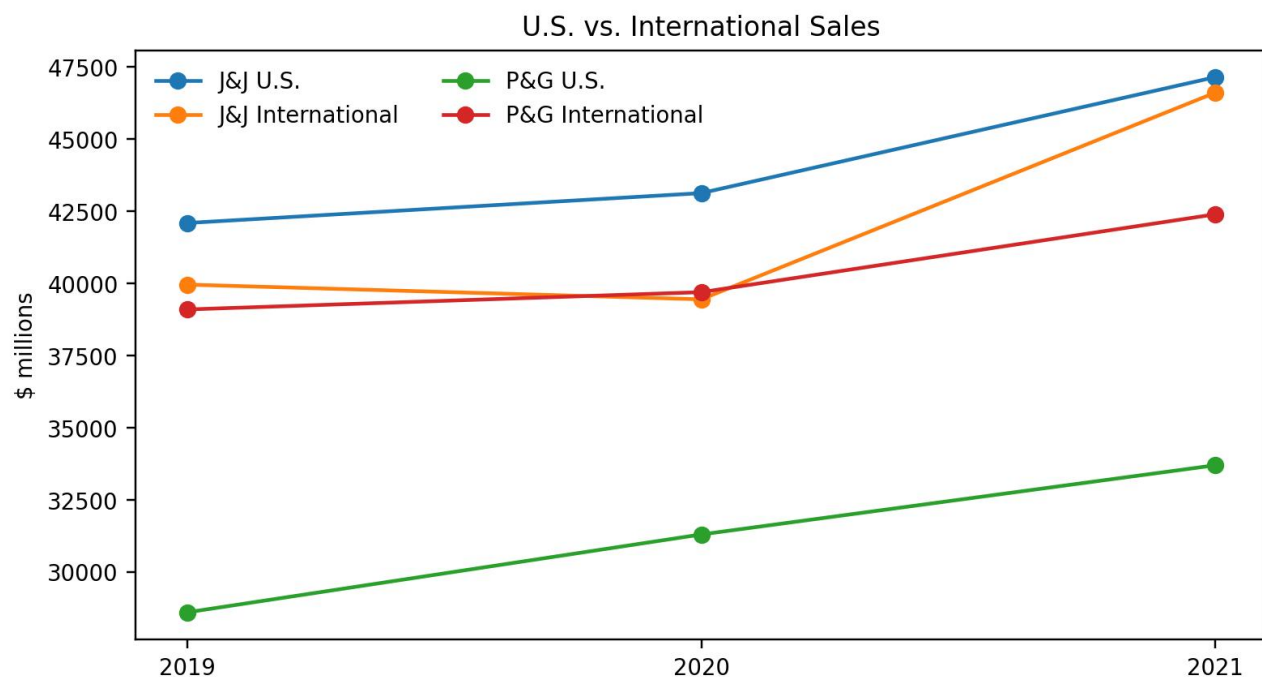


Figure 7. U.S. versus international sales

Source: J&J Geographic Expansion.xlsx and 2021 Form 10-K; P&G FY2021 Form 10-K.

Company / geography	2019	2020	2021	2019–2021 growth
J&J U.S.	42,097	43,133	47,156	12.02%
J&J International	39,962	39,451	46,619	16.66%
P&G U.S.	28,600	31,300	33,700	17.83%
P&G International	39,100	39,700	42,400	8.44%

Source: J&J Geographic Expansion.xlsx; J&J FY2021 10-K; P&G FY2021 10-K. \$ millions.

J&J's international acceleration was especially visible in Europe, where sales increased from \$18.5 billion in 2019 to \$23.6 billion in 2021, a cumulative increase of 27.8%. Asia-Pacific and Africa increased 11.1%, while the Western Hemisphere excluding the U.S. ended 2021 slightly below its 2019 level.

J&J geography	2019	2020	2021	2019–2021 growth
Europe	18,466	18,980	23,594	27.77%
Western Hemisphere ex-U.S.	5,941	5,335	5,750	-3.21%
Asia-Pacific & Africa	15,555	15,136	17,275	11.06%

Source: J&J Geographic Expansion.xlsx; \$ millions.

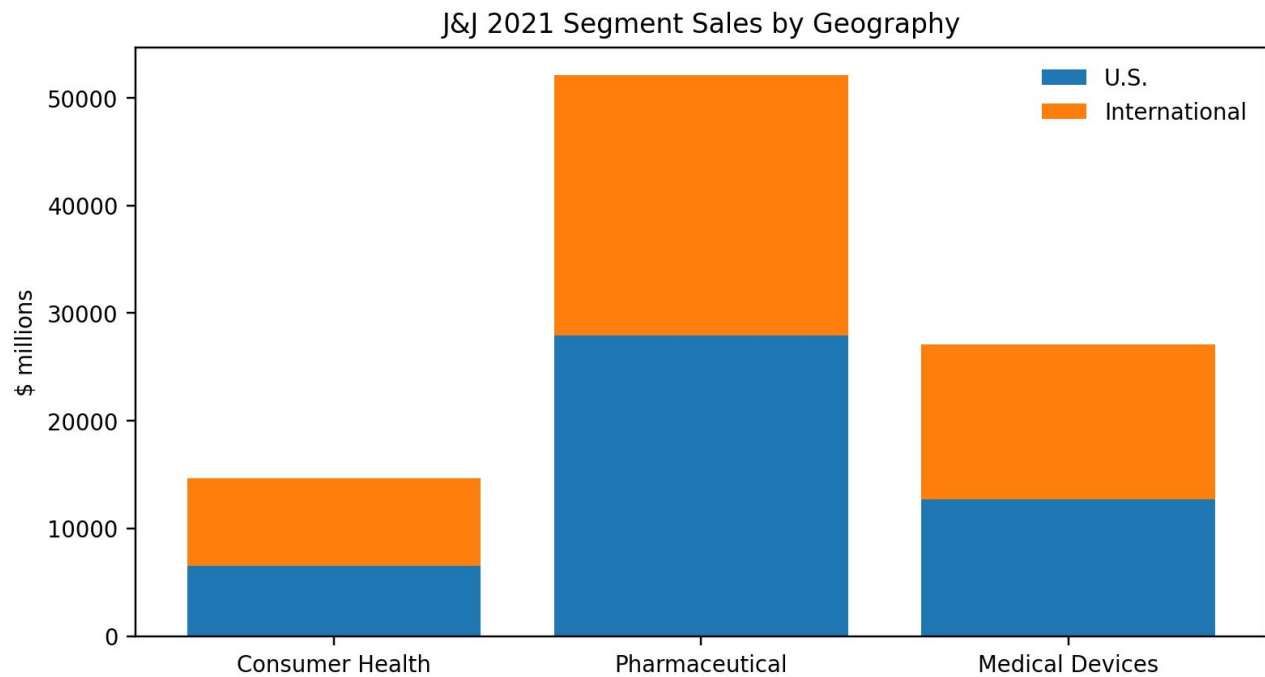


Figure 8. J&J 2021 segment sales by U.S. and international markets

Source: J&J Geographic Expansion.xlsx; \$ millions.

The segment-geography split reveals that Consumer Health was the most internationally weighted segment in 2021: approximately 55.5% of segment sales were international. Medical Devices was also majority international at about 53.1%, while Pharmaceuticals generated about 46.3% internationally. The fastest 2019–2021 international growth came from Pharmaceuticals, rising from \$18.3 billion to \$24.1 billion (31.7%).

This decomposition changes the strategic interpretation. J&J's international expansion was not simply a broad geographic effect; it was closely linked to the scale and growth of its Pharmaceutical portfolio. P&G, by contrast, remained highly international in absolute terms but grew faster in the U.S. during the study period.

9. Acquisitions, Divestitures, and Portfolio Reconfiguration

Acquisition and divestiture analysis complements ratio analysis by showing how management reallocates capital and reshapes future earnings capacity. This project identified a transaction-intensive pattern at J&J and a selective pattern at P&G during 2019–2021.

Year	J&J	P&G	Analytical interpretation
2019	Approx. \$7.7B of acquisitions, including DR. CI:LABO and Auris Health; divested ASP for approx. \$2.8B.	Merck OTC acquisition was a major Health Care portfolio addition; smaller brand activity also occurred.	J&J added consumer-health and robotic-surgery capabilities while pruning sterilization assets; P&G strengthened consumer health.
2020	Approx. \$7.2B acquisition activity included Momenta, bermekimab rights, and Verb Surgical; sold 8.3% Idorsia stake for approx. \$357M.	No comparably large acquisition; acquisition cash use was modest after Merck OTC; minor brand divestitures.	J&J continued capability acquisition in immunology and digital/robotic surgery; P&G emphasized integration and portfolio discipline.
2021	No material acquisition in the original project; divested two non-U.S. Pharmaceutical brands for combined proceeds of about \$0.6B.	Acquisition cash use was \$34M, primarily a minor Health Care acquisition; asset-sale proceeds were \$42M.	Both firms showed relatively light transaction intensity versus earlier years.

Source: Original MGT 211 project, cross-checked where possible against J&J and P&G Form 10-K disclosures.

The strategic significance differs by company. J&J's acquisitions were closely tied to scientific capabilities, specialty pharmaceuticals, and medical technology. This is consistent with a growth model in which externally sourced innovation can supplement internal R&D. P&G's Merck OTC transaction strengthened Health Care, but the broader portfolio trajectory around this era emphasized concentration on fewer, stronger consumer categories.

10. Integrated Comparative Assessment

Analytical dimension	J&J signal	P&G signal	Interpretation
Profitability	Higher gross margin; strong 2021 operating/net margins	Strong 2020–2021 margins; 2019 distorted by impairment	J&J has stronger structural gross economics; P&G normalized sharply after 2019
Liquidity	Higher current/quick ratios	Lower static liquidity ratios	J&J has larger conventional short-term buffer
Working capital	Positive but improving CCC	Negative and increasingly favorable CCC	P&G has superior cash-cycle efficiency
Leverage / coverage	Lower leverage; much higher interest coverage	Higher leverage; still strong coverage by 2020–2021	J&J appears more conservative on balance-sheet risk
Growth engine	Pharmaceuticals	Fabric & Home Care; Health Care	Different business models create different growth and risk exposures
Geographic growth	International > U.S.	U.S. > International	J&J's period growth was more internationally tilted
Transactions	Capability-building acquisitions + divestitures	More selective transactions	J&J relied more heavily on external innovation during the period

Source: *Synthesis of Sections 3–9.*

The strongest analytical conclusion is therefore multidimensional. J&J's advantage in margins, liquidity, leverage, and interest coverage does not negate P&G's superior working-capital efficiency. Likewise, P&G's negative cash conversion cycle does not imply that its overall financial position is unambiguously stronger. Each metric captures a different mechanism.

For business analytics, the case demonstrates why financial data should be modeled as a system of linked indicators. Profitability, liquidity, efficiency, solvency, product mix, and geography interact. A robust conclusion emerges from triangulation rather than from a single ratio.

10.1 A Research-Oriented Interpretation

The comparison also suggests research questions that extend beyond descriptive accounting. For example, how does segment mix explain cross-firm differences in working-capital intensity? How do acquisition strategies affect subsequent segment growth and margin persistence? How does geographic diversification interact with currency exposure and operating resilience? These questions could be investigated with panel data across firms and longer time horizons using econometric methods.

11. Limitations and Opportunities for Extension

- Fiscal-year mismatch limits strict same-period comparability. A future version could align quarterly observations to common calendar windows.
- The firms operate in different industries and segment economics. Ratio differences partly reflect business models rather than pure managerial performance.
- The analysis is descriptive and comparative, not causal. It identifies patterns and plausible drivers but does not estimate causal effects.
- Market valuation measures are outside the core scope. Adding total shareholder return, valuation multiples, and risk-adjusted returns could connect accounting performance to capital-market outcomes.
- The 2019–2021 window contains the COVID-19 shock. Extending the panel backward and forward would help distinguish temporary shock effects from persistent structural differences.

11.1 Reproducibility Roadmap

A next-stage research implementation would construct a tidy firm-year dataset directly from SEC XBRL facts, document each ratio formula, add automated validation checks, and reproduce all figures in Python. That workflow would make the analysis auditable and scalable to a larger sample of healthcare and consumer-staples firms.

12. Conclusion

This comparative case shows how financial accounting data can be transformed into business-analytics evidence.

J&J entered and exited the 2019–2021 period with a stronger conventional liquidity and solvency profile, higher gross margins, and a growth story increasingly driven by Pharmaceuticals and international markets. P&G combined lower static liquidity with exceptional working-capital efficiency and resilient growth in Fabric & Home Care and Health Care. Its 2019 profitability also demonstrates the importance of identifying unusual non-cash charges before drawing conclusions from reported margins.

The broader contribution of the project is methodological. Effective financial analysis requires data reconstruction, source validation, normalization of definitions, time-series and cross-sectional comparison, visualization, and interpretation of the economic mechanisms behind the metrics. Those practices connect accounting knowledge with the core logic of business analytics: converting complex data into transparent, decision-relevant insight.

Appendix A. Selected Original Ratio Data

Efficiency metric	P&G 2019	P&G 2020	P&G 2021	J&J 2019	J&J 2020	J&J 2021
A/R turnover	14.045	15.542	17.097	5.743	5.887	6.499
Inventory turnover	7.128	7.236	6.465	3.128	3.093	3.026
A/P turnover	3.257	3.054	2.900	3.443	3.192	2.971
Average payment period	112.78	119.51	125.88	106.01	114.37	122.87
Asset turnover	0.598	0.602	0.634	0.528	0.497	0.525

Source: Original MBA activity/turnover/efficiency tables; values rounded.

Appendix B. J&J Geographic-Segment Data

Segment	Geography	2019	2020	2021	2019–2021 growth
Consumer Health	U.S.	5,839	6,362	6,516	11.59%
Consumer Health	International	8,059	7,691	8,119	0.74%
Pharmaceutical	U.S.	23,874	25,735	27,954	17.09%
Pharmaceutical	International	18,324	19,837	24,126	31.66%
Medical Devices	U.S.	12,384	11,036	12,686	2.44%
Medical Devices	International	13,579	11,923	14,374	5.85%

Source: J&J Geographic Expansion.xlsx; \$ millions.

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